

successful: they all tried to imitate stories that had appeared in past issues of *The New Yorker*—not realizing that most of what is new, by definition, cannot be modeled on past issues of *The New Yorker*. Even the idea of a “short story” was a me-too concept to Yevgenia. The workshop instructor, gentle but firm in his delivery, told her that her case was utterly hopeless.

Yevgenia ended up posting the entire manuscript of her main book, *A Story of Recursion*, on the Web. There it found a small audience, which included the shrewd owner of a small unknown publishing house, who wore pink-rimmed glasses and spoke primitive Russian (convinced that he was fluent). He offered to publish her, and agreed to her condition to keep her text completely unedited. He offered her a fraction of the standard royalty rate in return for her editorial stricture—he had so little to lose. She accepted since she had no choice.

It took five years for Yevgenia to graduate from the “egomaniac without anything to justify it, stubborn and difficult to deal with” category to “persevering, resolute, painstaking, and fiercely independent.” For her book slowly caught fire, becoming one of the great and strange successes in literary history, selling millions of copies and drawing so-called critical acclaim. The start-up house has since become a big corporation, with a (polite) receptionist to greet visitors as they enter the main office. Her book has been translated into forty languages (even French). You see her picture everywhere. She is said to be a pioneer of something called the Consilient School. Publishers now have a theory that “truck drivers who read books do not read books written for truck drivers” and hold that “readers despise writers who pander to them.” A scientific paper, it is now understood, can hide trivialities or irrelevance with equations and jargon; consilient prose, by exposing an idea in raw form, allows it to be judged by the public.

Today, Yevgenia has stopped marrying philosophers (they argue too much), and she hides from the press. In classrooms, literary scholars discuss the many clues indicating the inevitability of the new style. The distinction between fiction and nonfiction is considered too archaic to withstand the challenges of modern society. It was so evident that we needed to remedy the fragmentation between art and science. After the fact, her talent was so obvious.

Many of the editors she later met blamed her for not coming to them, convinced that they would have immediately seen the merit in her work. In a few years, a literary scholar will write the essay “From Kundera to Krasnova,” showing how the seeds of her work can be found in Kundera—a precursor who mixed essay and metacommentary (Yevgenia never read Kundera, but did see the movie version of one of his books—there was no commentary in the movie). A prominent scholar will show how the influence